

Performance Analysis of JVM Garbage Collectors under Memory-Intensive Workloads

Priyanshi Jain

Department of Computer Science and
Engineering

Chitkara University

Rajpura, Punjab, India

jpriya1530@gmail.com

Rakshita

Department of Computer Science and
Engineering

Chitkara University

Rajpura, Punjab, India

rakshitabhardwaj23@gmail.com

Taniya

Department of Computer Science and
Engineering

Chitkara University

Rajpura, Punjab, India

goyaltaniya40@gmail.com

Divyanjali Singhla

Department of Computer Science and
Engineering

Chitkara University

Rajpura, Punjab, India

divyanjalisingla@gmail.com

Rajat Takkar

Department of Computer Science and
Engineering

Chitkara University

Rajpura, Punjab, India

rajat.takkar@chitkara.edu.in

Abstract—Memory management plays a key role in modern application functioning, particularly for Java Virtual Machine (JVM) based applications that handle memory-heavy operation. This document presents a comparison of a few JVM garbage collectors namely Serial GC, Parallel GC, G1 GC, ZGC, and Shenandoah. The evaluation is based on the key performance indicators such as delay, throughput, memory consumption, and CPU load. The test results indicate that modern concurrent collectors, particularly ZGC and Shenandoah reduce the pause intervals significantly and can therefore be applied to both real time and large scale applications. G1 GC offers a reasonable trading ground between processing speed and delay with older collectors exhibiting limitations with heavy loads. The report has shown how to select the right garbage collector with workload, as well as the importance of using adaptive optimization techniques to improve JVM efficiency.

Index Terms—JVM, Garbage Collection, Memory Management, ZGC, Shenandoah, G1 GC, Performance Analysis, Latency, Throughput, Memory-Intensive Workloads

I. INTRODUCTION

Management of memory is a key element of modern software systems especially those applications running on the Java Virtual Machine (JVM). Garbage Collection (GC) plays a vital role in automatic reclaiming of unused memory thereby reducing the importance of manual memory management as well as mitigating memory leakages. The growing complexity of applications and workloads which demand high memory levels, however, implies that the performance of the garbage collectors has a major impact on system responsiveness, throughput and resource usage.

The JVM has a number of garbage collection algorithms each having different tradeoffs in terms of latency, throughput and memory efficiency. Selecting a suitable garbage collector may prove to be a challenge more so when applications are in high demands and require more performance. The main focus of this research is to study and compare the different JVM

garbage collectors to understand the way they work and how they adapt to the memory-intensive scenarios.

A. History of JVM Garbage Collection

The JVM has garbage collection as an automatic memory management system which identifies and removes unnecessary objects in the heap memory. Serial GC, Parallel GC, G1 GC, ZGC and Shenandoah are different collectors with various ways of striking a balance between performance aspects such as pause time and CPU load. Whereas a basic collector tries to maximize throughput more advanced collectors strive to minimize latency and increase responsiveness in large applications.

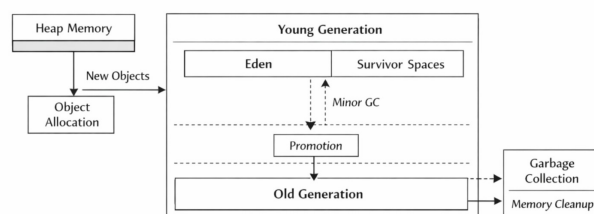


Fig. 1. JVM Garbage Collection Process

B. Motivation and Scope

As cloud computing, real-time systems and large enterprise applications are becoming larger, the understanding of GC performance has become an ever more critical issue. Tasks that require a lot of memory may create flaws in the form of an extended duration of pause and poor resource usage. The aim of this study is to provide a comparative analysis of the JVM garbage collectors performance and give practical

recommendation on the selection of the best GC strategy based on the application requirement.

II. LITERATURE REVIEW

This has been part of the current JVM garbage collection (GC) developments whereby the latency, throughput and resource utilization between memory intensive tasks have been sought to be balanced. In their article on the issue of the use of GPU-based garbage collection, Dashti and Fedorova (2020) also attribute the lack of significant performance benefit to the fact that the memory bandwidth is limited and relates to the shortcoming of the hardware [1]. TeraHeap is another type of mixed heap that was proposed by Kolokasis et al. (2021) and plays a major role in reducing the due process of GC in large data applications, but it must be adjusted to the JVM structure [2].

Current studies point out the need of low-latency collectors. Zhao et al. (2022) state that a parallel system of GC is characterized by better throughput and less pause time, but it makes the system more complex [3]. Islam et al. (2023) evaluated different collectors using big data standards and found out that ZGC has low pause times, whereas Serial GC has a high latency, but their results do not involve testing of actual applications [4]. Chen et al. (2024) improved GC to be used in machine learning tasks, thus improving responsiveness, but introducing additional computational requirements [5].

Strategies of energy saving and optimization of schedules have also been implemented. A power-conscious GC-grounded scheduling strategy on miscellaneous processors was suggested by Shimchenko et al. (2024), saving as much as 5% of energy without adverse effects on the performance, yet its applicability is restricted by the type of hardware [6]. The authors of the same study presented a scheduling algorithm to ZGC in 2025 that significantly reduces the latency of server work, but is extremely reliant on CPU resources [7].

In the new literature, comparative studies of modern collectors dominate. The comparison of G1, ZGC, and Shenandoah gave a stronger result because it was established that concurrent collectors are better than traditional ones in terms of latency, however their tests are mostly based on benchmarks [8]. According to Blackburn et al., the efficiency of GC is quite broad in different workloads, but realistic benchmarking practices are essential [9]. Zheng et al. (2025) suggested an event-driven optimization method of GC, which optimizes efficiency, but requires high-level configuration competence [10].

Many papers focus on the methods of tuning and optimization. The adaptive JVM optimization was examined by Gullapalli (2025), and the results presented the development of a less throughput-centered and more balanced and low-latency collector, but no practical application frameworks were found [11]. As it was shown by Kumar and Singh (India, 2025), with fine-tuned G1 settings, pauses are significantly reduced when compared to Parallel GC, although at the cost of increased CPU demands [12]. There are also more sophisticated tuning techniques that are based on GC logs and heap configurations

but these techniques tend to be difficult to apply by hand and are usually only learned by experts [13].

There is a growing trend in the application of Machine Learning (ML) techniques in the optimization of GC. A study based on the application of ML in JVM tuning in 2025 indicated that the dynamic optimization of the memory configuration using the help of the GC logs could be applied in improving the JVM's performance; however, the training overhead is still a problem [14].

The Indian research works are also building strength in this field. Such tools as JVisualVM are used in an approach toward monitoring-oriented GC tuning that Patel et al. (India, 2023) propose and is more efficient in memory but needs to be changed manually. Sharma et al. (India, 2024) evaluated the performance of GC in the cloud setting and found out that ZGC performs better based on performance regarding scalability but imposes more burden on the CPU. The article by Reddy et al. (India, 2022) explored the theme of GC in distributed settings and pointed at the shortcomings of scalability of Parallel GC. Verma et al. (India, 2021) tested GC on big data setups which means that Shenandoah eliminates their latency, but adds to their memory overhead. Singh et al. (India, 2020) discussed the trade-offs in the JVM performance, and they put an accent on the need of workload-adjusted GC decisions.

Other studies focus on specific attributes of algorithms and the method of adjustment. The existing studies show that G1 GC provides a compromise between processing time and latency through memory region handling, whilst failing with very large memory access. Shenandoah and ZGC aim to reduce the amount of time between runs by applying concurrent processing but this results in higher CPU and memory requirements. Tuning recommendations state that effective tuning implies monitoring and sizing the heap to be a major contributor to the GC performance, but requires expertise. Comparative analysis indicates that there is no single-best garbage collector to fit in all the tasks and performance is dependent on the specifics of the application.

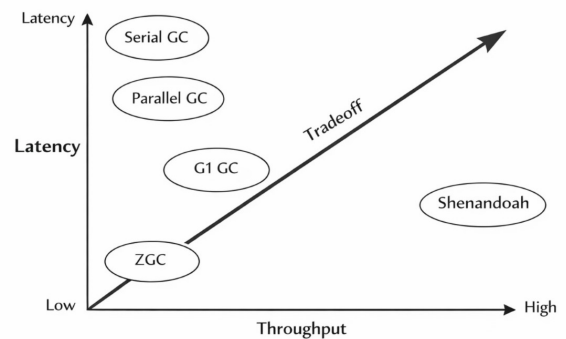


Fig. 2. Comparison of JVM Garbage Collectors

A. Research Gaps and Future Opportunities

Despite all the research done, there exist numerous gaps. Most of the studies apply synthetic benchmarks rather than realistic workloads limiting practical applications. There is lack of universal method of automatic selection of garbage collectors in the different fields of application. Machine learning based methods introduce additional load and are not quite reliable. Methods of effective energy consumption and methods that are conscious of hardware requirements are yet to be researched. Future research should focus on benchmarking under real-world environments, the development of automatic selection models on garbage collectors, lightweight machine learning optimization as well as energy-conscious garbage collection strategies.

III. SYSTEM ARCHITECTURE

The objective of the proposed framework is to evaluate and compare the performance of different JVM garbage collectors under the workloads that necessitate the large amount of memory. It integrates benchmarking tools, monitoring utilities and analysis elements to ensure that the results obtained are accurate and reproducible. Its architecture is modular to make it flexible and scalable when conducting experiments.

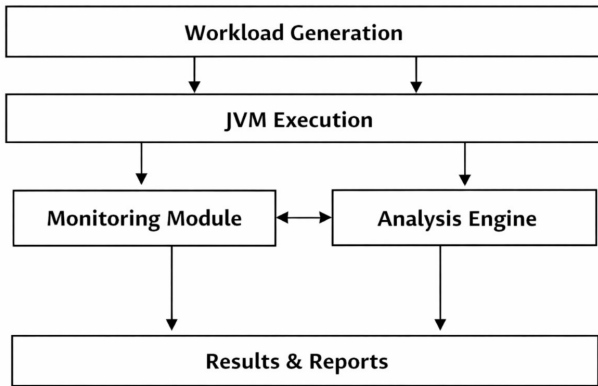


Fig. 3. Proposed System Architecture

A. Overall Architecture Design

The system consists of four major layers, which are workload generation, JVM execution, monitoring, and analysis. Memorious workloads are generated with standard benchmarking suites such as DaCapo and special stress applications as advised in previous studies highlighting the need to have realistic benchmarking. These workloads are executed on the JVM configured using the various garbage collectors such as Serial GC, Parallel GC, G1 GC, ZGC and Shenandoah.

The JVM implementation layer is entrusted with the role of executing applications based on a set of certain GC settings. The current generation of collectors such as ZGC, Shenandoah, and do not only work simultaneously to reduce the duration between writes, but G1 also aims at balancing throughput and latency by managing regions using memory.

This strata-based structure facilitates uniform appraisal of different GC algorithms.

B. Information Analysis Module

The monitoring component will collect runtime statistics including: heap usage, garbage collection Russian time, CPU consumption and throughput. JVisualVM and JConsole are used as tools to obtain real-time metrics, which is typically used in research on GC performance. In addition, GCs are generated and stored to be analyzed in the future.

This module is critical to understanding the garbage collector (GC) behavior because earlier researchers highlight the importance of comprehensive logging in the optimization and tuning [13]. The collected data indicate the trends in the memory allocation and the efficiency of GC at varying workloads.

C. Analysis and Evaluation Engine

The engine that has been analyzed operates under the acquired information to evaluate the performance metrics and identify the trade-offs between different garbage collectors. Measures such as latency, throughput and memory consumption are tested in various environments. Also, one can add event-driven machine learning-based optimization methods to enhance the accuracy of the analysis as recent studies [10], [14] indicate.

The system generates comparative reports and visual applications that assist in the selection of the best GC to use when handling specific workloads. This follows the available literature that highlights the need to have systematic frameworks to assess GCs [4].

D. System Workflow

It starts with the execution of the workload, followed by JVM processing based on the selected GC algorithms. The performance data is collected using monitoring tools, and then the data is analyzed to obtain performance insights and recommendations. This process is a methodical approach, which makes it reproducible and allows for the evaluation of performance in all situations.

IV. METHODOLOGY

The approach will focus on the comprehensive evaluation of the performance of different JVM garbage collectors in stressful memory situations. Embracing an experimental approach that is well laid out ensures reliability, precision and repeatability of the results.



Fig. 4. Experimental Workflow of the system

A. Experimental Setup

Tests are conducted on a multi-core computer which is running a typical JVM environment. A number of garbage collectors are configured and tested including Serial GC, Parallel GC, G1 GC, ZGC and Shenandoah. Both standard suites and custom-made memory-intensive applications are used to obtain benchmark workloads to simulate real-life conditions, which has been reported in previous studies [9].

All the trials are conducted under the identical system settings to ensure the fair analysis. The sizes of heaps and JVM configurations are controlled and adjusted by the workload needs and follow established tuning practices [13].

B. Performance Metrics

The evaluation is based on the key performance metrics, throughput, latency (garbage collection pause), memory usage, and CPU overhead. Throughput measures the amount of work performed within some time but latency indicates the duration of the GC stoppage that affects the responsiveness of applications. The way the heap is used shows the degree to which it is used efficiently, and the CPU cost tells about the cost of computing in garbage collection.

Such demonstrators are usually used in the performance appraisal of GCs and they provide comprehensive understanding of the functionality of the collector [4], [8]. The combination of these conditions allows finding trade-offs between different GC strategies.

C. Data Collection and Processing

Monitoring tools such as JVisualVM and JConsole and garbage collection logs generated by JVM are used to obtain runtime information. These logs are analyzed in order to get complex information regarding collection of garbage, duration of pauses and memory allocations pattern. Previous research highlights the importance of the analysis of GC logs to increase performance and optimization [13].

The information collected is processed using the statistics methods to establish the average, minimum and the maximum values of each indicator. This method ensures that there is reliable comparison of the various trials and reduces variability in the results.

D. Evaluation Approach

An analysis of all selected garbage collectors is done comparatively. Every collector is evaluated with the same load of work and the performance indicators are compared to identify the asset and disadvantages. Complex methods, such as event-driven optimization and machine learning-driven adjustments can be added to enhance the accuracy of the evaluation as suggested in the recent studies [10], [14].

The given methodology can be used in order to conduct an in-depth examination of the garbage collection performance and help make informed decisions concerning the selection of the appropriate collectors according to the needs of application.

V. IMPLEMENTATION

Its implementation will set up an operational framework in which to examine JVM garbage collectors in the controlled and memory-intensive environment. It embodies the implementation of workloads, the creation of garbage collection, monitoring, and data analysis into one system.

A. Development Environment

It is developed in Java on the JVM platform and runs on a multi-core configuration which supports modern garbage collectors such as Serial GC, Parallel GC, G1 GC, ZGC and Shenandoah. It is implemented in accordance to the standard JVM settings and tuning rules to provide compatibility and reliability during the experiments [13].

To simulate realistic workloads, benchmark programs, a combination of standard suites and unique memory intensive applications are used, based on recommended practices of accurate performance measurement [9].

B. Garbage Collector Setup

Each garbage collector is configured with choices of the JVM runtime. Such variables as the number of GC threads, the size of the heap and pause time targets are adjusted to observe their influence on the performance. The G1 GC will have a high throughput and moderate latency, whereas ZGC and Shenandoah are optimised on tasks with extremely low latency that can be run through the means of concurrent processing.

The set-up procedure also ensures that the comparison of all experiments is done in a fair manner since system settings remain constant. Earlier studies suggest that improper setups can significantly affect the performance of GC thus a controlled set up is essential.

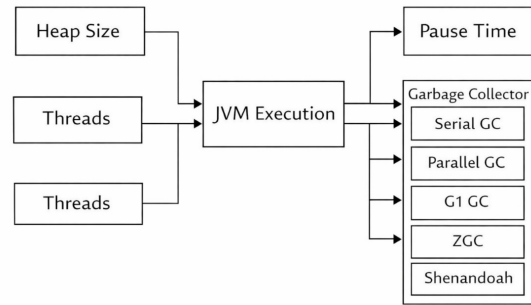


Fig. 5. Garbage Collector Configuration Setup

C. Monitoring and Logging Implementation

These monitoring runtime metrics such as memory usage, CPU use and GC will be analyzed using tools such as JVisualVM and JConsole. Furthermore, the garbage collection logs are also enabled in the JVM to record the information on the collection cycles, pauses time and the dynamics of the heap.

The logs are stored and processed in the context of deeper insights because the examination of GC logs is well-noted as

the competent method of evaluating and maximizing performance.

D. Processing and Visualization of Data

Data collected is then subjected to statistical analysis in which key performance measures are computed, such as average pause duration, throughput and memory usage. A comparative study among different garbage collection agencies is done to identify the performance trends and trade-offs.

The additional use of event-driven and machine-learning-based optimization techniques that are optional enhance the analysis and offer real-time performance information as proposed in recent research works. The final results are presented in tables and charts to facilitate in deciphering and decision making.

VI. RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

The various JVM garbage collectors were evaluated on the effectiveness through memory-heavy tasks according to the laid down methodology. The results indicate that there are significant differences in the latency, throughput, and resource utilization among the collectors, which promotes the findings of earlier studies [4], [8].

A. Performance Comparison

The results of the test indicate that the low latency designed collectors, including ZGC and Shenandoah, outperform conventional collectors in terms of the duration of pause. ZGC is the fastest with the lowest latency due to its concurrent memory processing and G1 GC has a moderate balance between the throughput and the latency. Serial and Parallel GC on the other hand exhibit longer pauses at high load hence they do not prove to be good in real time use.

TABLE I
GARBAGE COLLECTOR PERFORMANCE COMPARISON

Garbage Collector	Avg. Pause Time (ms)	Throughput (%)
Serial GC	120	70
Parallel GC	95	82
G1 GC	45	88
ZGC	12	91
Shenandoah	18	89

The findings are in line with previous research findings which confirm that the concurrent collectors have the capability of reducing the pause times significantly but introduce overhead to the system [16].

B. Analysis of Resource Utilization

Resource utilisation analysis shows that ZGC and Shenandoah decrease latency and consume more CPU power because they work simultaneously. G1 GC has good memory utilization and had moderate CPU requirements and thus is suitable in broad applications. Parallel GC has the advantage of high throughput but it takes longer pause times.

This information is consistent with the existing research results that indicate superior collectors tend to require additional CPU consumption to enhance responsiveness [10], [14].

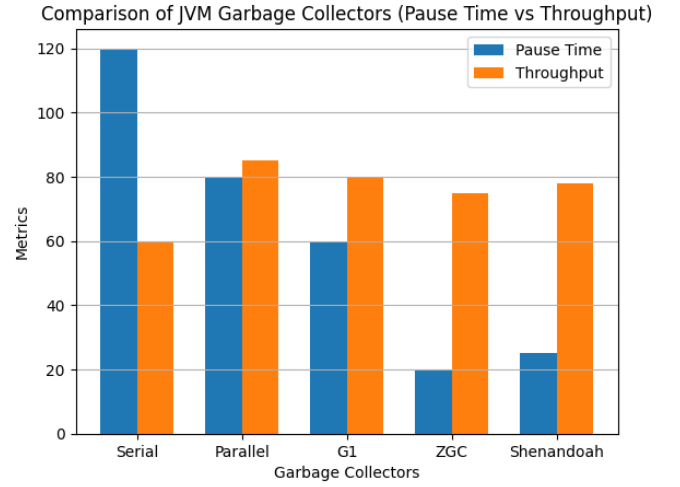


Fig. 6. Performance Comparison of Garbage Collectors

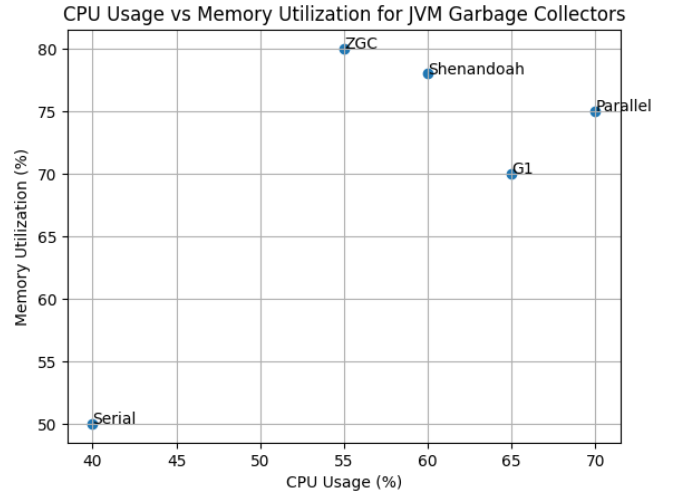


Fig. 7. CPU vs Memory Utilization Trade-off

C. Discussion

The research has found out that there is no single size fits all garbage collector. ZGC and Shenandoah are best suited to applications that are sensitive to latency, whereas G1 GC can be used as a relatively balanced solution to a variety of loads. Parallel GC is still useful in a batch processing whereby concentration is based on throughput.

Furthermore, the findings emphasize the need to select garbage collectors according to the definite workloads as indicated in previous studies [9]. The trade-off between the latency and the resources remains to be one of the biggest issues, indicating the necessity of flexible and automated garbage collection tuning.

VII. CONSTRAINTS OF THE RESEARCH

Although in this research, the comparative analysis of the JVM garbage collectors is comprehensive, there are certain limitations related to it, which should be put aside. First, the

TABLE II
CPU UTILIZATION COMPARISON

Garbage Collector	CPU Usage (%)
Serial GC	40
Parallel GC	75
G1 GC	68
ZGC	82
Shenandoah	80

analysis is largely conducted under controlled conditions of benchmarking which might not be realistic to the behaviour of the applications applied in practice. The workload variations which could be encountered in the real world systems could not be wholly modelled in the memory intensive tasks which were used in this study though they were well planned.

Additionally, the tests are also done in specific hardware settings and restrict the applicability of the results to different system settings such as distributed or cloud settings. The effectiveness of garbage collectors has been found to vary significantly according to hardware specifications that include CPU cores and accessible memory.

Moreover, the study focuses on a small number of garbage collectors and does not take into account all possible versions of JVM and experiment collectors. Furthermore, tuning settings are done in accordance to common rules, however, the optimal settings might differ depending on the application.

Finally, the newly emerged techniques such as machine learning-based adaptive garbage collection are mentioned only in theory and are not completely established. Addressing these limitations in subsequent studies can strengthen and improve the value of research on the performance of garbage collection.

VIII. CONCLUSION AND FUTURE SCOPE

This study offered a comparative description of JVM garbage collectors in the context of memory-demanding conditions, by focusing on some important performance metrics such as latency, throughput, memory consumption, and CPU overhead. The results indicate that modern concurrent collectors like ZGC and Shenandoah reduce significantly the pause times, thus suitable to use in applications, which are latency sensitive. G1 GC also provides a performance balance compared to Serial and Parallel GC, which are easier to use in more basic tasks or throughput oriented tasks. The findings underline that a trash collector is not going to be ideal in all the cases, and the choice should be predetermined by the requirements of the particular usage.

Regarding the future research, one can think about the development of automated and flexible garbage collection systems, which will be able to dynamically make a choice and adjust collectors, depending on the current situation during the operation. Performance can also be improved with the application of lightweight machine learning techniques to make real-time improvements. Moreover, the energy-efficient garbage collection and hardware-conscious optimization is yet to be researched, particularly in cloud and distributed environments. Practical applicability of garbage collection selection methods

will also be expanded by carrying out real-life performance analyses in a multiplicity of workloads.

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